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The Effects of Religious Participation and Brand Image on Commitment to Donate to Faith-Based Charities

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ABSTRACT

Charities are in constant need to raise funds and thereby solicit donations through requesting the public and corporate enterprises. The satisfaction of a brand image by public or corporate enterprises can be highly motivating for raising funds. The main objective of this research is to identify a charity's brand image and its relationship to trust, commitment, and emotions which are not only critically important for enhancing the charity's image but also leveraging motivation for donorship. It examines participants and their influence on image, trust, commitment, and emotions toward a religious or faith-based charity. Structural Equation Modeling and multigroup analysis are used to examine the results. It shows that Faith-based charity's image has a positive association with many of the antecedents. The charity's brand image didn't influence emotions directly but indirectly through commitment. Multigroup analysis shows there were some differences noted between the group frequency of religious dedication. The study makes two broad contributions, first, the research broadens the theoretical framework of the brand image regarding religious or faith-based charities by demonstrating how trust, commitment, and emotions influence their image and motivation to donate. Secondly, it enhances the understanding of the diversity of trust and its broader impact on the dedication of religious group participation. By differentiating between the marketing image and brand image, the research provides suggestions for improving the charity's brand image.

KEYWORDS

Charities; trust; emotion; donors; religious participation and religious charities

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Introduction

Australia currently has over 57,000 registered charities but this number is only growing by four percent every year (Coggan, 2019). Statistics showed that in 2015–16, around 14.9 million Australian adults (i.e. 80.8% of the population) offered 12.5 USD billion to charities and not-for-profit organizations. Equating this figure to 10 years ago, it was found that a smaller proportion of Australians are giving, but the proportion of amounts donated appears to be larger than before (Giving Australia, 2019). Similarly, donation failure to charities has been an issue afflicting many countries (Cheuk et al., 2018), despite them increasingly expected to sustain themselves while at the same time making a considerable contribution to society's welfare. A continuing increase for motivating donorship is required for charities to achieve sustained success and while many areas can be used to improve motivation to donate, the charity's image can be an important and a key source of attraction for donors. Brand images create perceptions that shape behaviors and lead customers to make informed decisions regarding donations (Durna et al., 2015). Examining the image of a faith-based or religious charity is critical, given the prevailing literature that implies religiosity is a major determinant of brand image, hence the question as to how would brand image influence commitment, trust, and emotions?

The nexus between faith-based charities and religion has its roots in history. Religions have impacted the faith of many individuals and have directly influenced individuals to have distinctive thoughts and behaviors based on their religious beliefs (Choi, 2010). While it is the basic foundation for establishing norms, judgments, attitudes, and actions for some individuals (Baazeem et al., 2016), it is also a leading cultural value in several societies and can affect diverse intra-personal factors (Bhuian et al., 2018). Studies have shown that religion is a stronger predictor than individuals' moral values, on consumer's ethical beliefs (Arli & Pekerti, 2017). There are many empirical studies conducted on the effect of religious priming for prosocial behavior (Shariff et al., 2015) and charities are no exception.

Faith-based which are religious charities are the largest sole group of charities in Australia, their involvement can range from serving community congregations to serving large providers of essential services, particularly in education, hospital, ambulance, aged care, housing and disability services (Knight & Gilchrist, 2015). This has increased their popularity twofold and while these faith-based charities are valuable, as they have a huge amount of funding to support the social economy (Bahramitash et al., 2018), they also make a huge and debatably under-recognized contribution to Australia's infrastructure and communal well-being (Knight & Gilchrist, 2015), which has often gone unnoticed and seldom investigated.

Donors are criticized for neglecting the essence and significance of religion for not going beyond its direct relevance for development. For example, faith-based institutions such as churches, temples, or mosques within this perspective can be seen as partners in development, as they have access to local communities, wide-ranging networks, and direct capacity to work with the poor which makes them useful for implementing these development activities (Petersen & Le Moigne, 2016). Given that charitable giving can be categorized as an “investment” for better wellbeing and is much needed to support communities, it requires insights on the influences of a charity’s image and how is it likely to facilitate commitment. Similarly, what marketing efforts can be expended to add value? Can these faith-based institutions through their spiritual affiliation and commitment make a difference?

Faith-based charities are unique, as it creates a sense of affiliation, where people who belong to faith are likely to donate to their type of religion or faith-based charities. Understanding how religious service attendees perceive and are committed to faith-based charities would also provide a better understanding for practitioners to position their brands. This research presents the findings of a study that sought to examine the brand image of a faith-based charity and provide suggestions for building their marketing image.

The main objective of this research was to identify the brand image and its relationship to trust, commitment, and emotions which are not only critically important for enhancing the charity’s image but also leveraging motivation for donors. It will also aim to examine the multigroup (high, low or no) religious dedication by participants and their influence on image, trust, commitment, and emotions toward a religious or faith-based charity. These findings will inform the scholarship of the literature within this increasingly important area. Lastly, the research highlights how marketing a brand image can attain a higher level of attraction toward potential donors of the future. The research suggests that a charity’s brand image should not be underestimated but recognized as an emergent multi-dimensional perspective for attracting donors. The study makes two broad contributions (1) the research broadens the theoretical framework of the brand image regarding religious or faith-based charities by demonstrating how trust, commitment and emotions influence their image and motivation to donate (2) group cohorts for religious dedication enhances the understanding of the diversity of trust and its broader impact on commitment. By differentiating between the marketing image and brand image (proposed by Barich & Kotler, 1991), the research provides suggestions for improving the charity’s brand image.

Together they make an important contribution in understanding the brand image of a faith-based charity and religious service attendance for supporting future marketing developments in the context of fundraising and donations.

The rationale for this study

It is increasingly recognized that a charity's image characterizes the sum of beliefs, and impressions (Barich & Kotler, 1991); and that a brand's trust, commitment, and emotions are increasingly dynamic for increasing sales or motivation to donate. While Barich and Kotler (1991) assert that a company's corporate or brand image and its marketing image are distinct, it is clear that a brand image would determine how the public views a charity in terms of goodwill toward society and the perspectives of other stakeholders. A charity's brand image relies on what they do, the services they offer, and the public they are required to serve. On the other hand, they claim that a charity's marketing image consists of how the public rates the "exchange value" of that charity's offering. The marketing image is specified as the "exchange value" which in essence is not the same. For example, Mathur (1996) draws insights about exchange value, based on the theory of exchange, suggesting that exchange value for charities is different from products and can be motivated by donors' self-interest (Pitts & Skelly, 1984), altruism (Sherry, Jr., 1983), or their importance, self-esteem, and recognition (Haggborg, 1992; Kotler & Andreasen, 1987). For faith-based charities, it may be their religious attachment, or even religious participation by attending religious services (e.g., attending church services). Economists and social psychologists have often endeavored to understand charitable giving based on the supply side of donations – in other words "why should people make sacrifices for others?" (Briers et al., 2007, p. 2) and equally, what are the antecedents that drive faith-based participants to make sacrifices, such as donations to support charities?

A good charitable brand image, as a result, may not necessarily contribute much should it lack a weak marketing image. Since both, the charitable image and the marketing image influence behavior with the public (Barich & Kotler, 1991). In the eyes of religious participants and their likely donor behavior or funding, the charity's image become fundamentally important to examine. More importantly, identifying the impact of a brand image will assist donors in making informed decisions. With faith-based charities specifically, where donors are the "agents of transformation" who engage with the varied value systems of these faith-based organizations and support the poor (Clarke, 2007), these findings could be an important turning point for improving the brand image that would lead to increased donations.

We synthesize the literature arising from the concepts which is seen as an amalgamation and extension of properties (Parsons, 1996). It is critical to choose an accurate collection of ontological categorizations (Sowa, 1995). Based on the literature in the table below we address the areas of interest and their inter-relationships thereof (Guarino, 1997). Combined together, which will assist to form our hypotheses.

Against this background, this research investigates a particular charity's brand image to further understand the impact of religious participation on donor behavior. It considers a charity's brand image in light of what appears to be lacking in the literature on the influence of religious participants' motivation to donate concerning trust, commitment and emotions. Identifying these factors will show charities why they need to direct their marketing efforts to increase their brand image with their target market (religious participants). Since brand image plays a central role in the overall achievement of charities, we use it as the key variable of interest. These variables are discussed in the following sections.

Charity's image

To remain distinct and successful, charities use branding as a key marketing tool (P. Hankinson, 2001 as cited in Voeth & Herbst, 2008, p. 72). A good brand image likely attracts potential for donations. Brand image has often been confused with reputation. Balmer (1998) provides insights on corporate identity and has indicated that the literature on corporate image and corporate identity disclose distinct aspects of development and there are nuances between an organization's identity (or identities) and its image(s) and reputation(s). Corporate reputation as defined by Weigelt and Camerer (1988 p 1) shows that "a corporate reputation is a set of attributes ascribed to a firm inferred from a firm's past actions". This helps to build commitment or loyalty toward a brand. Balmer (1998) draws this distinction by proposing that reputation is the perception an individual will hold toward an organization that is formed over a period of time and concentrates on what an organization does and how it behaves. On the other hand, an image concentrates on the beliefs about an organization. For instance, "the corporate image is nothing essentially new. It is in all essentials, merely the picture which your organization has created in the minds of your various publics." (Bristol, 1960, p.13). Other researchers have given varying interpretations of image, which generally involves knowledge, feelings, and beliefs about an organization that is in the reflections of its audiences (see Hatch & Schultz, 1997). Furthermore, while reputation can be closely related (but contrasts from) image, implies a value judgment about an organization's qualities (Balmer, 1998; Bennett, 1998). While this "image" is built through carefully constructed integrated marketing communication, it may not necessarily be matched by a persuasive reputation, in other words, charities require both a prominent image and a good reputation (Bennett, 1998).

Consequently, this inherent identification of brand image is reflected quite readily in the conceptual works of several authors. For example, a brand image is the reflection of the knowledge, feelings, and beliefs individuals have regarding the firm, and through which they recognize, know, describe, recall,

and relate to that firm (Huang & Ku, 2016). Hudson (2008) proposes several reasons as to why we need to brand for fundraising performance, for example, brands can assist in learning and education. If the public is aware of the charity and the charity's brand name, then values associated with it facilitates improved performance. Hudson (2008) asserts that brands are also known to reduce the risk for a donor which follows from the agency theory, where donors use nonprofits to act on their belief as agents in disbursing funds; they also provide the focus for supporting relationships. As there is clear evidence in the literature that brands develop relationships or bonds which is a strong predictor of brand commitment (Veloutsou, 2015); lastly, branding results in cognitive preferences and acts as reputation insurance to a nonprofit.

Commitment is also believed to be related to loyalty (Sargeant & Woodliffe, 2007). Commitment can be conceptualized as a continuing desire or intention to growing and sustaining a stable relationship (E. Anderson & Weitz, 1992; Gundlach et al., 1995). In a crisis, people prefer to support better-known charities, or the more popular ones (Michel & Rieunier, 2012). While knowledge regarding what a charity entails and the meaning of its perceived image is important, yet its objective, reputation, and its commitment are critical to making informed choices about donations. Inadequate understanding of faith-based charities may have been a relentless issue for many and a missed opportunity. Equally the perceptions of a good brand image can improve long-term commitment (Ogba & Tan, 2009; Tu & Chang, 2014). Others have also found that corporate image has a positive significant influence on customer commitment (Richard & Zhang, 2012) and an important antecedent of commitment and loyalty (Yu-TeTu & Hsu, 2013). Thus, we propose the following hypothesis based on the discussion above:

H1: The image of the charity positively relates to the trust that individuals have for the Charity

H2a: The image of the charity positively relates to the commitment that individuals have for the Charity

H2b: Commitment mediates the effect of the charity's image with emotions for the charity

Emotions

Marketers are under the impression that high-quality image products have always appealed to emotions (Mahajan & Wind, 2002). Yet, within the context of appeals from charities, it is not uncommon to find research on emotions such as sadness, anger, fear, and guilt (Ford & Merchant, 2010). Emotions are the effect of concerns and motivate goal-directed behaviors to help to safeguard and extend

these concerns (Zeelenberg & Pieters, 2006). The emotional value also represents the complete valuation of benefits and sacrifices (Veloutsou & Delgado-Ballester, 2018). Without a doubt, appeals to donate regularly evoke an emotional response from consumers and influence their behavior (Dean & Wood, 2017; Dillard & Peck, 2000). There is a strong belief that the stories narrated by charitable organizations are intended to capture the consumer's experience of different emotional phases (Merchant et al., 2010). Ford and Merchant (2010) found that nostalgic charity appeals induce a much higher level of emotions and donation intentions when compared to non-nostalgic appeals. While emotive appeals for donations are universal, guilt appeals are very common within the context of fundraising (Hibbert et al., 2007) and for influencing behavior (Bennett, 1998). Moreover, donating does not account for any impersonal exchange, but is a response to a serious human condition, making donating a personal matter that involves emotions and value judgments (Burt & Strongman, 2005).

It is clear from the above that donors can obtain utility from charitable giving due to their emotions (Sargeant et al., 2006), and psychologically through a feeling of well-being (Dunn et al., 2008). Given that emotions are strong within charities, it is also possible that people involved in religious commitment can influence emotional utility, as religions teach their members to care for others (Wuthnow, 1991). For example, emotions such as happiness increase charitable behavior (Isen & Levin, 1972). Generally, it is implicit that the decision to donate is founded on the emotion of the cause (Johns, 2004). Furthermore, behavioral change can be enhanced if individuals can identify with brands and feel an emotional attachment (Hudson, 2005). A good brand image is necessary for creating powerful emotional bonds (Richard & Zhang, 2012). Similarly, emotional utility drives commitment for charitable giving, and, indeed, some emotional attachment is so strong that donors felt guilty if they do not give to their favorite charity (Sargeant et al., 2006). Some researchers have found that influences of guilty emotions can be both, exogenous as well as endogenous leading to increased prosocial behavior (Ketelaar and Tung Au (2003). Consistent with the above discussion, the following hypothesis is proposed:

H2c: Commitment is positively related to the emotions people have regarding the charity.

H3: The Charity image positively influences emotions people have regarding the charity.

Trust

For charities to flourish, they must uphold high levels of public confidence and trust. Trust is recognized as the basis on which many voluntary organizations

are founded (Michel & Rieunier, 2012; Seligman, 1998). Trust plays an important role in defining and establishing the credibility and legitimacy of a charity and in creating a greater moral tone in the minds of its main stakeholder groups and donors (Bruce, 1994; Sumption, 1995). According to the Australian Charities and Not-for-profits Commission (see www.acnc.gov.au), building public trust in charities is one of its vital objectives. Even though a donor's trust in a charity is an assumption (Johns, 2004), the notion of trust is at the core of a charity (Herzlinger, 1996; Mullin, 1995). Charities depend on the public's trust to continue and to achieve their charitable missions (Bourassa & Stang, 2016; Sargeant & Lee, 2004). For nonprofits, such as charities, the brand image should focus on the central values of the organization (in this case it would be religion), trustworthiness, humanity and idealism (Voeth & Herbst, 2008). It is also believed that the commitment/trust theory makes relationship marketing more operative (Melewar et al., 2017).

Higher degrees of trust are often associated with a greater willingness to become a donor and to give larger sums (Burnett, 1992; Sargeant, 1999; Saxton, 1995). In the literature, engendering trust is seen as critical for charities by many participants surveyed (Tapp, 1996). Transparency is fundamental, as donors would not only want to see the entrusted value from their donations (Forbes, 1998; Grant Thornton, 2008) but also trust that these donations have targeted the right cause (Wilson, 2009). Similarly, for charities to thrive and succeed, they must hold high levels of trust (Gaskin, 1999). Brand image is necessary to develop trust (Richard & Zhang, 2012). There is evidence that the unfavorable brand image is likely to decline the level of consumer trust (Swan et al., 1999). Similarly, commitment to a brand rises from trust in the brand (Tu & Chang, 2014). Hence, we postulate the following hypotheses:

H4: Trust of a charity is positively related to the commitment of that Charity

H4a: Trust of a charity mediates the effect of the charity's image with commitment people have toward that charity

Conceptual model

Following the above discussion, we propose the intended model and hypotheses in Figure 1. It addresses the research question as to what extent does a charity's image influence trust, commitment, and emotions.

Faith-based religious charities

Some scholars have examined donor engagement with religion and faith-based organizations where the focus is on the role and relevance of religion (Petersen

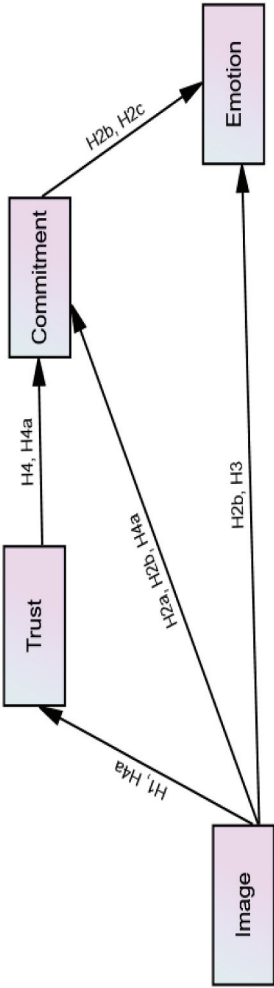


Figure 1. Conceptual Model.

& Le Moigne, 2016). While religion is the main foundation of social capital and community engagement, this research scholarship is focused on attending religious services. Even though there is limited research available on faith-based charities (Bunds et al., 2016), there is no attachment between individuals and charitable organizations, like religious affiliation which constitutes a large part of the charity topography (Guidestar, 2014). Much of this effort has resulted in rather mixed findings that have not added specific marketing value in terms of increasing motivation to donate.

As discussed above, assessing the impact of donor behavior on religion and charitable giving is not new (e.g., Jackson et al., 1995; Lam, 2002; Reitsma et al., 2006). A faith-based charity can have a great influence on religious meanings and meeting sacred goals (McCarthy, 2017). People are motivated to donate for varying reasons and the findings are often underlined by mixed views regarding religious beliefs and their link to charities. Religious beliefs are known to influence charity and research has shown that religious beliefs and their affiliation toward charitable organizations lean positively toward generous donations (Ranganathan & Henley, 2008). Many studies have found strong associations between the practice of religion, attending church, and their impact on charitable behavior (Hoge, 1995; Schneider, 1996). Furthermore, religious attendance has a stronger association with giving in male-headed households in the US (Eagle et al., 2018). Rajan et al. (2009) find that a decrease in the level of religiosity was associated with a decrease in the probability of being an international or domestic donor and vice versa. Ranganathan and Henley (2008) perspective on charity and religion is that they are founded together, as most of the religions underline the importance of helping the needy. Those that practiced their faith and are committed, for instance, attend masses at church, were twice as likely to volunteer (Wilson & Janoski, 1995). Church attendees were also found to be more altruistic (Smith et al., 1999). Christians were found to be the most likely to donate. One particular reason is the motivation to give for religious causes and the second reason is related to a sense of duty (Van Slyke & Brooks, 2005). The relationship between charity and religion can also be seen as tautological as membership, attendance, and giving which are all drivers of religious contribution (Bekkers & Wiepking, 2011). Participation strongly motivates the desire to give (Bekkers & Wiepking, 2011; Showers, Showers, Beggs, and Cox, 2011; Vaidyanathan & Snell, 2011).

Wuthnow (1991) when controlling for age, gender, region, and education, found that attending church frequently and listening to the teachings, increases volunteering and the potential to give to charities. While there is evidence in the literature to show that people who identify themselves as having a religion and regularly participating in religious services are likely to donate more on average (Lyons & Nivison-Smith, 2006), further understanding of their perception of the charity and the antecedents is yet to be recognized. Charities with different types of religious faiths, to some extent show

support for giving. For instance, Christianity has regarded giving as a key religious act of charity. Similarly, Judaism, Islamism and Buddhism also see the notion of giving as a strong tradition in their religions. There are assumptions that religious participants can be categorized as a mixed group, and interfaith differences are noticeable and expected, yet intra-faith differences are also predominant (White et al., 2018).

The aim of religious giving goes beyond what it would bring to an individual, rather, it is more a contribution to societies and communities for the betterment of their well-being. When Muslim donors to charities were investigated, there were five ways through which religiousness established itself in the framework of charitable behavior, namely, role modeling, seeking rewards, seeking self-satisfaction, avoiding guilt, and seeking congruence (Jamal et al., 2019, p. 319).

While some believe that religion may impact charity (Ryckman et al., 2004), others are more controversial in their beliefs, namely that religious people are narrow-minded with little concern for others (; Fisher et al., 1994). These mixed views lend themselves to investigate by segregation between the groups involvement in high, low or no religious dedication. Clustering similar groups will help, as they do develop bonds, a sense of community, and a social structure with people within the group who share the same brand sentiments (Taute et al., 2014; Veloutsou & Guzman, 2017). This is well regarded within the branding context where interacting with other consumers and with brands collectively, consumers also decide to belong to brand-related groups (Veloutsou & Guzman, 2017). Following the above discourse, we also test the moderating effects of three groups, those that are high, low or had no religious dedication on the following:

- a: Group differences significantly moderates the relationship between the image of faith-based charities and trust for faith-based charities
- b: Group differences significantly moderates the relationship between between the trust and the commitment for faith-based charities
- c: Group differences significantly moderates the relationship between the commitment for faith-based charities and having emotions for faith-based charities
- d: Group differences significantly moderates the relationship between the image of faith-based charities and the commitment of charities
- e: Group differences significantly moderates the relationship between the image of faith-based charities with emotions of charities

Methodology

Sampling

The sample was selected from people who reside in a suburban metropolitan area in the Australian city of Melbourne and attended a charity fundraising

event. In other words, attending a fundraising event would mean receiving some private benefit, unlike a more altruistic way of helping a charity (Webber, 2004). This could be seen as indicative of the combination of people wanting to be supportive of a charity or just honoring an occasion. On arrival, the sample was distributed to the audience. We obtained a convenient useable sample of 247 responses. The survey was voluntary, and participants were given ample time to complete it. The questionnaire featured only one main religious charity. The questionnaire adopted previously validated items and was modified from Furnham (1995), Sargeant et al. (2006), and Hibbert (1996), and Webb et al. (2000). Likert scales, measuring strongly agree to strongly disagree on a 7-point scale, attempted to measure the participants' responses. Often religion is used as a key psychographic characteristic to distinguish between donors and non-donors and religious mindedness (Ranganathan & Henley, 2008). Participants were segregated into three base on their religious dedication. Those respondents categorized as high dedication comprised 28% of the total responses, those that were low comprised of 54% of the sample and 18% reported as no religious dedication. For multi-group modeling, the rule of thumb is 100 cases/observations per group (Kline, 2005). More recent research has stated that the generalizability required for the study is more a determining criterion than the statistical method for sample size (J. F. Hair et al., 2017).

Demographics

In this research, 25% of males, as compared to 75% of females, responded to this question. Very few (3%) were in the 18–24 age group and a large majority were in the 55+ age category. In terms of household incomes, there was a reasonable dispersion of respondents with low and high incomes – 27% preferred not to state their income and around 7% reported an income of 100,000 USD plus. Concerning education, the participants that finished high school represented around 3%. Around 10% had a postgraduate qualification and 4% had a Ph.D. qualification. Similarly, regarding employment status, the participants that were employed represented around 34%, followed by 22% who were retirees, the rest of the sample were either self-employed, students, or homemakers.

Measurement model

The Exploratory Factor Analysis was analyzed by IBM SPSS Statistics 25. Outliers were screened and factor analysis was considered to be appropriate after performing the following tests: The Bartlett's Test of Sphericity ($p = .000$) was less than .05 and the Kaiser-Meyer-Olkin measure of sampling adequacy was significant and above .6 (.893) (Pallant, 2005). Together the Total Variance Explained for these four factors accounts for 60.1% of the variance in the items extracted. This qualifies for the minimum amount of variance (60%) (J.F Hair

et al., 2010). The extraction method used was Maximum Likelihood and Promax rotation with Kaiser Normalization – the rotation converged in seven iterations.

For the measurement model, a two-step approach was used as indicated by J. C. Anderson and Gerbing (1988). To confirm the internal consistency and validity of the constructs, validity measures and composite reliability were also calculated (J.F Hair et al., 2010). Initially, all multi-item constructs were included except religious service participation which was a binary coded variable.

Employing the fit indices, the measurement model fit was analyzed for the chi-square statistic (χ^2), comparative fit index (CFI), incremental fit index (IFI), and root mean square error of approximation (RMSEA) (Hu & Bentler, 1998). Three loadings that were below 0.3 were discarded. The CFAs consequently showed a good fit with all the standardized regression weights above the .50 benchmark and significant loadings on all items, except for one which we decided to retain (see Table 2). The results demonstrate that constructs relate to the tests for convergent construct validity while the observable variables also demonstrate strong explanation interpretability to latent variables. The fit indices were shown as equally reasonable and were within the recommended range: $\chi^2 = 135.429$, degrees of freedom [df] = 92; $p = .002$; CFI = .97; IFI = .97; TLI = .97, GFI = .93, AGFI = .91, NFI = .93 and RMSEA = .04.

With regards to determining reliability, convergent validity, and discriminant validity. Composite reliability (CR) was used to demonstrate the reliability of a construct. CR is a reflective method of general reliability and it attempts to evaluate the uniformity of the construct, apart from the strength and equality (J.F Hair et al., 2010). The recommended level for CR is estimated to be equal to or above .70, which would indicate that there is a high internal consistency of the scales and good reliability. In the following Table 1, the CR estimated is equal to or above .70. Similarly, the average variance extracted (AVE) for nearly all the variables was well within the recommended range (.50) with the exception of reputation which had an estimated AVE of 0.47. Based on Fornell and Larcker (1981) the AVE is seen as a moderate evaluation of the validity of the measurement model. It is suggested that depending on the composite reliability only, it can be ascertained that “... the convergent validity of the construct is adequate, even though more than 50% of the variance is due to error” (Fornell & Larcker, 1981, p. 46). This research has estimated all the CR values of all the constructs is over the stipulated recommendable level of .60, the CR values in this research are equal to or > .70, thus, the internal reliability of the measurement items can be suitable (Fornell & Larcker, 1981; Huang et al., 2013).

Table 1. Literature Synthesis.

THEMES	FINDINGS	SOURCE
Motives for charities	The main causes for charitable giving are to help the poor/needy and support religious causes.	Kasri (2013).
Brand and reputation of charities/ trust and commitment	The type of charities and reputation are important in gaining donor's trust in order to continue to support charities and build a firm commitment	Hsu et al. (2005).
Commitment and loyalty building	Commitment is also believed to be related to loyalty	(Sargeant & Woodliffe, 2007).
Attitudes and motivation	Highlighted the moderating role of religious beliefs on attitudes toward charities and motivation to donate.	Casidy et al. (2014).
Donation intention and religious beliefs	Identified that people with religious beliefs and affiliations would donate liberally to charitable organizations	Ranganathan and Henley (2008)
Charitable intention	Intrinsic-extrinsic religiosity -debatable as to whether religion influences charitable deeds	Ryckman et al. (2004)
Depth of religion and the impact on charitable giving	Found that those who are deeply religious are extremely caring and more willing to perform charitable acts	Ryckman et al., 2004
Intention to give	The overabundance of studies on donation behavior are mostly centered around how people donate	Van Slyke & Brooks, 2005; Kottasz, 2004; Clary & Snyder, 1995)
How and why decisions are made.	Donation decision-making process	; Smith & McSweeney, 2007)
Influences on decisions	Influence of perceptual and attitudes on donation behavior	Sargeant et al., 2006; Webb et al., 2000; Sargeant et al. (2006). Webb et al. (2000)
Typology of donors	Donor characteristics that affect donations	Schlegelmilch, Diamantopoulos et al. (1997a), Schlegelmilch, Love et al. (1997b)
Influences on intention	Attitudes and charitable giving in practice	Radley and Kennedy (1995)
Theory of planned behavior	Identified charitable giving is effective through a revised TPB model that predicted donation intentions and behaviors	Smith and McSweeney (2007)
Motivations to give	Rationale for giving	Van Slyke and Brooks (2005)
Donor commitment	Donor commitment is best regarded as a multidimensional construct.	Sargeant and Woodliffe (2005).
Motivations to commitment	There are varying motivations that lead individuals to give to charity. Draws a distinction in commitment	Morgan (1996).
Monopolistic charity	Shows the likelihood that a commitment by a monopoly charity to an allocation rule that is, ex-post, privately sub-optimal can eliminate this effect, and may therefore be advantageous, ex-ante.	Bilodeau and Slivinski (1997).
Trust in charities	Security and trust in the charity are a key motivating factor for many donors.	Kelly et al. (2014).
Trust, commitment and donorgiving	Operationalizes trust and commitment by developing measurement scales for each construct. Determines whether trust directly affects giving behavior or whether its effects are mediated by commitment. Identifies that commitment plays a mediating role	Sargeant and Lee (2004).
Internal branding	Internal brand is complex, consist of four components: the functional, symbolic, behavioral, and experiential	G. Hankinson (2004).

(Continued)

Table 1. (Continued).

THEMES	FINDINGS	SOURCE
Likely to trust and commitment	Identified that individuals are more likely to believe in organizations that share their core values; likely to support the most trusted charities. The level and commitment of support increases as trust in the charity increases.	Furneaux and Wymer (2015).
Commitment type of social relations	Three possible bases of social relations: normative commitment, coercion, and utilitarian material	Adloff (2006).
Importance of trust	Trust is a critical issue in those charities that are values-based organizations	Gaskin (1999).
Trust and commitment are reciprocal relationships	Trust and commitment to charities are necessary to establish reciprocal relationships	(Guh et al., 2013)
Commitment and donor giving	Commitment to charities positively influences donor giving behavior	(Sargeant & Lee, 2004)
Trust mediator	The expectation of charitable donation can guide their action while trust plays a mediating role	Liu (2019).
Emotional utility	Emotional ethics of larger charities have been met with resistance from the public and press	Dean and Wood (2017).
Emotional impact	Differentiates between making a financial donation and buying cause-related marketing (CRM) products as two different types of helping modes.	Li and Atkinson (2020).
Emotional response	The results showed that emotional response to charities has an influence on the preliminary decision to donate or to abstain from any donations.	Agyemang et al. (2019).
Emotional rewards to giving	Demonstrate that people experience very different emotional rewards from giving to charities with similar missions	Aknin, L. B., Dunn, E. W., Whillans, A. V., Grant, A. M. & Norton, M. I. (2013).
Emotional branding to differentiate	Furthermore, charities use intangible attributes such as values and emotional brand attachment with the brand to differentiate itself from the competitors.	Casidy et al. (2014).
Negative emotions	Assesses the effect of negative emotions and empathy generated by emotional charities' campaigns on numerous variables of advertising effectiveness.	Albouy (2017).
Emotional empathy	Empathy mediates the relationship between the type of charity, attachment to the charity and making a donation.	Richman et al. (2015).
Emotional engagement	Traits related with emotional engagement, service, voice, and tradition are qualified of serving as the foundation for differentiation and are also nuanced with giving behavior	Sargeant, Ford, & Hudson,(2008).
Brand image	Developed a scale to measure the brand image of charities. Shows that Brand image explains up to 31% of intentions to give money and 24% of intentions to give time.	Michel and Rieunier (2012).
Nonprofit brand image and need for investigation	Nonprofit brand image plays a critical role in determining consumers' charitable donations and therefore nonprofit organizations must be aware of how consumers perceive them.	Michaelidou et al. (2015).
Brand image for smaller organizations	A small charity must first determine its values and market positioning and gain extensive consent internally before it can move on to create and implement a successful brand identity.	Dixon (1997).
Importance of image	Image of charitable organizations is likely to have a positive influence on attitudes toward charities.	Casidy et al. (2014).
Branding and need for investigation	The necessity for charities to have a brand is still controversial	Saxton (1995).

(Continued)

Table 1. (Continued).

THEMES	FINDINGS	SOURCE
Brand image and personality	Given that charities who have developed and promoted their personalities have been successful, it warrants a case for charities doing this as part of their brand image.	Tapp (1996).
Brand image important for services	For other less well known charities to create shop branding the retailers have to offer a distinct type of service	Horne (1998).

Table 2. Factor Loadings, AVE, CR, Mean and Standard Deviation.

	FL	MEAN	STD DEV
Commitment AVE .47 CR 0.85			
I would describe myself as a loyal supporter of this charity	.695	3.59	2.065
I feel a sense of belonging to this charity	.689	3.78	1.770
I will be giving more to this nonprofit next year	.511	5.11	1.86
It is clear what work that this charity does	.749	4.46	1.769
I care about the long-term success of this charity	.727	4.13	1.794
There is public recognition for giving to this charity	.684	3.57	1.334
There are often opportunities to donate to this charity	.708	4.52	1.619
Image AVE .60 CR 0.85			
I believe this charity shows compassion	.537	6.33	.915
This charity performs their duties well toward society	.722	5.79	1.51
This charity is successful in helping the needy	.930	6.06	1.30
My perception of this charity is positive	.868	6.12	1.052
Trust AVE .60 CR .80			
I would trust this charity to use donated funds appropriately	.455	5.83	1.325
I would trust this charity to conduct their operations ethically	.955	5.66	1.444
I would trust this charity to always act in the best interest of the cause	.834	5.95	1.43
Emotions AVE .66 CR .70			
If I never gave to this Charity, I would feel bad about myself	.748	2.92	1.742
I often give to this Charity because I would feel guilty if I did not	.875	2.60	1.449

To establish discriminant validity, we adopted the process used by Fornell and Larcker (1981) by comparing the AVE and the correlation coefficient of the constructs. Table 2, shows the diagonal elements within the correlation matrix are the square roots of the AVE. This value is required to be higher than the off-diagonal elements in the corresponding rows and columns.

In Table 3, it can be seen that the square root of AVE is larger than the correlation coefficient. It can be established that all the variables have a positive discriminant validity (Fornell & Larcker, 1981). The correlations are all significant ($p < .05$) and in the anticipated positive directions. The study also used the common method variance (CMV) to identify biases. Harman's one-factor test was followed to indicate eigenvalues, the first factor revealed 35.20% variance, which is within the recommended levels of less than 50% and therefore CMV can be ascertained.

Measurement invariance

In order to establish the moderating effects of religious dedication, measurement invariance was conducted to accept configural, metric, and scalar

Table 3. Correlations.

	TRUST	IMAGE	COMMITMENT	EMOTIONS
TRUST	0.77			
IMAGE	.689**	0.77		
COMMITMENT	.526**	.547**	0.68	
EMOTIONS	.130*	.203**	.407**	0.81

invariance (Hu & Bentler, 1998). In Table 4, the configural invariance showed CFI =0.939; TLI = 0.920 and RMSEA 0.042 for the configural invariance. The metric invariance indicated CFI =0.930; TLI = 0.918 and RMSEA 0.043. The chi square difference between the configural and metric invariance significant (χ^2 49.5050, df = 32 and $p < .05$). Suggesting the differences between the models. Further test on sensitivity to sample size (Byrne & van de Vijver, 2010; Cheung & Rensvold, 2002). The configural and metric model indicated that constrained model has equally good indices, therefore supporting metric invariance (Steenkamp & Baumgartner, 1998)

Structural model

Goodness-of-fit measures were employed to assess the overall model fit. The overall fit indices for the proposed model were acceptable and within the range. The $\chi^2/df = 3.222$ (DF = 1; p -value, .073), RMSE = .095, goodness-of-fit index = .99, incremental fit index = .99, AGFI = .93, comparative fit index = .99, and PClose = .161. These fit indices for the overall model indicated a good fit (Bagozzi & Yi, 1988; Bentler, 1990; Kline, 2005).

As displayed in Table 5, all the hypothesized paths in the model are significant at the alpha level of .01 with the exception of the charity's image to emotion toward the charity which was not significant. Hypothesis 1 Charity's image is positively related to trust toward the Charity is significant and has the highest beta values as compared to other hypotheses ($\beta = .68$, $p < .001$). Hypothesis 2a Charity's image is positively related to commitment toward the Charity ($\beta = .35$; $p < .001$) is also significant and so is hypothesis 2 c and hypothesis 4 – Commitment is positively related to emotions of the Charity and trust is positively related to the commitment of the Charity; hypothesis 4, commitment to emotions toward the charity is the next largest beta value ($\beta = .42$; $p < .001$), followed by hypothesis 2a image and commitment ($\beta = .35$; $p < .001$). Hypothesis 3: Charity's image positively influences Emotions regarding the charity was not significant.

Table 4. Invariance Testing.

Model	CMIN	DF	χ^2 Difference
Configural	396.812	5.721	
Metric	446.317	308	49.505/32**

Table 5. Estimates.

			Estimate	S.E.	C.R.
Image	-->	Trust	0.689***	0.045	14.901
Trust	-->	Commitment	0.284***	0.132	3.986
Image	-->	Commitment	0.351***	0.129	4.92
Commitment	-->	Emotion	0.421***	0.07	6.059
Image	-->	Emotion	-0.027	0.128	-0.391

Table 6. Summarizes the direct, indirect, and total effects of variables.

Outcome	Determinant	Direct	Indirect	Total
Trust (R^2 0.47)	Image	0.68**	...	0.68**
	Commitment	0.28**	19**	0.28**
	Emotions	...	0.23**	0.12**
Commitment (R^2 0.34)	Image	0.35**	...	0.54**
	Trust	...	...	...
	Emotions	0.42**	0.12**	0.42**
Emotion ($R^{20.16}$)	Image	-0.02	...	0.20**
	Emotion	...	...	...
	Trust	...	...	0.12**
	Commitment	...	...	0.42**

Table 6 summarizes the direct, indirect, and total effects of variables. As hypothesized, with H4a: Trust mediates the effect of image on the commitment of the charity was found significant. In other words, the effect of trust is mediated through image and reputation. Whereas with H2b commitment mediates the effect of image on emotions regarding the charity. The direct effect on the image on emotions was not significant but with the mediating variable of commitment, the indirect effects were significant. Trust and commitment both play a significant mediating role in the image of a charity

Moderating group effects

A multigroup analysis was used to identify the path coefficients between groups and the association with the charity's image, reputation, trust, and emotions, to see if there were differences between the groups in relation to high, low and no religious dedication. The respondents had to respond to the regularity of the attendance at religious services and those that never or seldom attended. The two-step process was followed to conduct the multi-group comparison test by constraining the structural parameters to be equal across groups and to develop an approximate covariance matrix for each of these cohorts (Ko et al., 2010), the other was to unconstraint the parameter quality constraints. The χ^2 value for the set of sub-models as a component of a single structural system was tested to evaluate the significant differences that exist between the two χ^2 values for determining the moderator effects.

The unconstrained baseline model was compared each of the moderating hypothesized paths for the subgroups by constraining each one. The moderation results show that only

the group differences between the trust of charities with the commitment of charities was significant ($\beta = 0.18; p < .05$). Thus, the analyses show that although trust was a significant driver for all three cohorts, the effect of trust on commitment were consistent across all cohorts. In the context of this study, this lack of effect may occur because many respondents may evaluate their experiences with religious groups differently.

Discussions

The main objective of this research was to identify the brand image on antecedents such as trust, commitment, and emotions. It also examines group influence and their moderating role on image, trust, commitment, and emotional utility toward a religious or faith-based charity; the research attempts to provide insights on how marketing a brand image can attain a higher level of attraction toward potential donors of the future.

From the above analysis it can be seen that the faith-based charity's image had a positive association with trust; trust positively associated with commitment to donate. Similarly, the charity's faith-based image had a positive association with a commitment to donate. Our research is supportive of the literature on brand image and its effect on the commitment to donate (Michel & Rieunier, 2012;). While the commitment to donate had a positive association with emotion, a faith-based charity's image was found non-significant to emotion but showed full mediation with a commitment to donate. In other words, a faith-based charity's image only influences emotions toward charity when individuals are committed to donating. This is an interesting finding, as Charities are claimed to be natural emotional raisers, and donors should connect with any messages regarding emotional issues with which charities entail (Tapp, 1996), but yet the charity's brand image didn't influence emotions directly but indirectly through commitment. This is unlike the findings in the literature whereby brand image was required to create powerful emotional bonds (Richard & Zhang, 2012).

It was clear that the charity's image had a direct positive influence on trust and trust mediated the effect of the charity's image and commitment to donate. This is in line with the findings in the literature where brand image is required to develop trust (Richard & Zhang, 2012). Our findings support some of the nuances between differences groups who may have an affiliation and association (Bekkers & Schuyt, 2008). Researchers have found that although religious individuals offered more in terms of giving, and the association of religion on preference for charity brands was positive but it was not statistically significant (Bennett & Gabriel, 1999). There are mixed findings, research has also shown that religious commitment can be a complement to or a substitute with the level of charitable giving where strong evidence that religious giving and religious commitment are substitutes, where greater

subsidies to charitable giving lead to more religious giving, but less to religious commitment (Gruber, 2004, p. 2365). This is contrary to our findings that show with faith-based charity image, where trust has a significant positive relationship with commitment. It is likely that many beliefs and behaviors which have been embedded very deeply, despite individuals compelled to forsake their congregations would nonetheless persist to believe in God, trust others and donate to charity (Bottan & Perez-Truglia, 2015). However, faith-based charitable image and its association with emotions were not found to be significant with the groups. This does not support the “private consumption” model that proposes a warm glow or emotional effect (Handy & Katz, 2008).

The above analysis justifies a need to have more emphasis on channeling emotions to increase the charity brand effectiveness, not only amongst religious participants, but secularists or nonbelievers can also be targeted as potential prospects. Furthermore, charities should attempt to evoke emotional reactions in potential donors. This can be achieved through strong advertising and emotional appeals, more particularly in evoking the emotional benefits that often result – for example, the gratification of assisting someone (Sargeant, 1999). While faith-based charities are hoping to assist the poor in the short term, they must be aware of their long-term brand image and its consequences.

Marketing and practitioner implications

The last objective was to provide insights into how marketing a brand image can attract potential donors of the future. Religion and marketing always had a substantial level of interest and should be given attention for future growth (Cutler & Winans, 1998). Marketing and consumption studies highlight a diversity of complex phenomena that are embedded in secularized societies where both religious organizations and new spiritual movements compete (Rinallo & Alemany Oliver, 2019). Thus, making it more necessary to increase the brand image to operate in a competitive marketplace.

The marketing of religious charities is different from the marketing of general charities. For example, the Catholic church will have Catholic charities that play a major role through their religious-led affiliations, unified faith, and structured beliefs. This is evidenced through several studies showing strong associations between the practice of religion, attending church and their impact on charitable behavior (Hoge, 1995; Schneider, 1996). Thus, the marketing of a religious charity lies in the religious institution's brand image. As alluded to earlier, the market image is the “exchange value” of a charity's offering (Barich & Kotler, 1991). Very often an institution's controversial social views on issues, such as abortion and homosexuality, or the criminal

behavior of priests, can be damaging to this image and, in turn, can severely affect perceptions of a charity's brand image.

The findings of this study, such as the charity's brand image and its influence on trust, commitment, and emotion, can be used in conjunction with a donor's self-interest, altruism, self-esteem and recognition (Pitts & Skelly, 1984; Sherry, Jr., 1983; Haggberg, 1992;; Kotler & Andreasen, 1987) to demonstrate or extend exchange theory. Both the marketing image and a charity's image aim to influence behavior in various communities (Barich & Kotler, 1991). Public trust in charities is important for the sustained strength of the charitable sector (Yang et al., 2016). More specifically, it was also found that people with more institutional trust are likely to accept indicators of trustworthiness of organizations (Janssen, 2016). To build institutional trust would require both the marketing image and a charity's brand image to be supported. Barich and Kotler (1991) are of the view that when firms are attempting to measure and manage a marketing image, they must ensure that the process is feasible, affordable, and repeatable and that the attributes are actionable. They also propose that the marketing image not only seeks to encourage consumers but also to elicit recommendations from others.

Constant publicity is necessary through a mix of different marketing methods to create awareness and the use of social media is also encouraged to build trust. Charities need to intensify trust in their activities for obtaining their share of donations (Voeth & Herbst, 2008). Essentially, greater public understanding would lead to an elevated trust in a charity's situation. While many individuals do trust charities, the level of trust should be kept continuous, since higher degrees of trust are often associated with a larger willingness to grow into a donor or donate extensive amounts (Burnett, 1992). Different marketing offerings, therefore, can increase their trust in charitable causes by signaling their trustworthiness to the public. This also encourages the creation of social structures that can result in trusting relationships developing, mainly among similar religious-based donor groups.

Other marketing issues, such as commitment, were also examined in the study. The charity's brand image is positively associated with commitment, this is critical, as a commitment not only leads to obtaining valuable outcomes but also able to identify with and take pride in an organization (Beatty & Kahle, 1988). Arguably, loyalty and commitment can be synonymous, while it is also believed that they are related but distinct, and that commitment leads to loyalty (Fullerton, 2003). Marketing efforts should also focus on encouraging loyalty, as this would lead not only to stronger commitment but also to customer retention (E. Anderson & Weitz, 1992; Park et al., 2016). Image not only had a positive association with commitment but was found to mediate brand image and emotions. Finding the means to increase commitment is important for the long-term success of retaining dedicated religious participants and potential participants.

While recent studies of branding in the nonprofit context have contributed to brand image and brand personality (Shehu, Becker et al. 2016), the important contribution of this study is that it highlights the importance of trust, commitment and emotional utility for faith-based charity brands. Branding is incorporated within the actions of marketing, and the brand image a donor develops, regarding a charity and its cause, is the result of several activities (Tapp, 1996). Antecedents, such as commitment, trust and emotional utility, have not been previously considered as a critical element of the charity's brand image and marketing image for faith-based charities. Marketing practitioners concentrating on faith-based charities should be aware of the significance of brand image and the important implications of commitment and trust, both of which were found significant in this study. For example, faith-based charities could maximize their local deeds to increase donors' perception of how they are supporting social problems. Lastly, while limited research has regarded faith-based charities from the moderating role of religious dedication and the impact of image, trust, commitment and emotion, the findings of this study will allow practitioners to address these issues for enhancing the quality of their competition by differentiating themselves from other charities.

Limitations and future research

This study investigated the results focused on a single charity, and some inferences can be made regarding the generalizability of the results. However, it sets the argument that trust and commitment are significant for building a charity's perceived image. Trust was seen both as a predictor, mediator and showed a moderating significance between trust and commitment for groups. Thus, the trust in religious charities should also be examined in further detail through measures, such as an institutional trust for the brand image and personal disposition to trust.

Surveys of individuals pose a mono-method bias. Future studies should design a multi-method framework for examining charities and perceptions of their faith-based brand image, as well as how they have positioned themselves. A note of caution, as these are self-reported measures, can result in social desirability bias and care should be taken when deciphering them. Besides, the research uses convenience sampling, which is a non-probability sampling method with several disadvantages, as the data is collected from a set of population members who were conveniently available to participate in the study. More random sampling may have yielded more variation in the results. Other types of faith-based charities should also be considered in future research which may invoke different results, as well as identifying a charity's marketing image that consists of the "exchange value" for motivation to donate, such as the sacrifice exchanges donors are willing to make to support worthy causes. Researchers are still to engage with the question of how and

why donors elect to support religious charities and don't pay attention to others.

This research has only laid the foundation and explored the tip of the iceberg and recommends future researchers use the findings of this study as their platform to explore further. The research recommended strategies to improve marketing offerings that would aim to support the tenets of the marketing image's exchange value. It contributes to offering insights to distinguishing between a charity's perceived image, as well as to identifying future shifts in trust and commitment of a charity's image, not only among their target market but also among non-regular religious participants, secularists, or nonbelievers who should be targeted as potential prospects. The study offers insights for charities that are facing a decline in a highly competitive environment.

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